

Why Is Everybody Drinking Guinness?

[C2]

Un tempo associata ai tradizionali pub irlandesi, la Guinness sta conquistando sempre di più i giovani americani. Grazie all'influenza dei social media, le vendite di questa iconica birra scura sono salite alle stelle.



When Maxwell Quinn [stepped out](#) of the November [chill](#) into Clandestino, a bar in Manhattan's Chinatown favoured by a young, fashionable crowd, he quickly passed over the [sparkling wines](#), dirty martinis and Lagunitas IPA. "Can I get a Guinness?" he said. He wasted no time. Before the [foam](#) could [settle](#), he raised the glass to his lips and tilted [his head back](#). He began [to chug](#). Quinn, thirty-six, was '[splitting](#) the 'G,' an online trend in which drinkers [gulp](#) Guinness with the hopes that the horizon between the [stout](#) and the [foam](#) falls in the middle of the 'G' on a [branded](#) pint glass. In some corners of the internet, it seems like everyone — the Jonas Brothers, John Cena, your cousin — is [splitting](#) the 'G.' Guinness, once synonymous with old Irish pubs and old Irish men, is increasingly [winning over](#) younger, [beer-bent](#) Americans like Quinn. "It's having a moment," he said. You can [spot](#) Guinness in some unexpected places across New York City, including Mexican restaurants, [diners](#) and natural wine bars. It is the fastest-growing imported beer in the country based on bar, restaurant and [brewery](#) sales over the last year, according to Nielsen. The Dublin-based brewer has been [making up](#) for ground lost in the United States since the pandemic. But it's more than post-pandemic revenge spending. A [motley](#) of factors — an Irish pop cultural renaissance, viral drinking challenges and of course, marketing dollars — has helped [endear](#) one of the beer industry's most misunderstood products to skeptics. "The numbers are completely [bananas](#) right now," said Oran McGonagle, an owner of the Dubliner, a two-year-old pub in Boston. In 2023, his bar sold more Guinness than any other bar or restaurant in the city. And this year, the Dubliner's [purchasing](#) volume of the [stout](#) is up 63 per cent to meet [rocketing](#) demand. Guinness' boom is a [byproduct](#) of a larger cultural moment, said McGonagle, who is from County Donegal, Ireland. In recent years, Irish cultural figures like actor Paul Mescal and author Sally Rooney have introduced Americans to a cooler version of Ireland. Guinness, which was [hardly trendy](#) when he lived there, is benefiting. "Irish culture is having a big [resurgence](#)," he said. "We're at the peak of where we've ever been." Sales have been strongest in cities with large populations of Irish Americans, said Joyce He, the US brand director for Guinness. The company's [top-performing markets](#) are New York City, Chicago, — where Guinness opened a [brewery](#) last year —, Philadelphia, Washington, DC, Boston, and South Florida. "During the pandemic, Guinness was disproportionately affected," she said, as most of its sales occur at restaurants and bars because so much of the quality relies on the tedious [pour](#) from the [keg's tap](#). The recent [uptick](#) is partly the result of people missing a drinking experience they could only have in person, she said. Pub owners said Guinness is [shedding](#) its reputation as a "[meal in a glass](#)," thanks in part to marketing campaigns aimed at [dispelling](#) the notion that the beer is heavy. The [stout](#) is 4.2 per cent alcohol by volume — about the strength of Bud Light — and 125 calories per 12 ounces [340ml], lighter than Modelo Especial. That [appeals to](#) Americans [wearied](#) by [craft beer's](#) dominance, said Mike O'Sullivan, an owner of New York pubs Hartley's and Grace's. "Everyone is drinking Guinness," he said. That was not the case in 2015, when he opened Hartley's in the Clinton Hill neighbourhood of Brooklyn. Guinness sales were

strong from the start — the [stout outsold](#) the rest of the menu 3-to-1 — but it was mostly ordered by Irish men. “Americans preferred craft beers,” he said. That changed during the pandemic. “You would look up and down the bar and everyone was drinking Guinness,” he said. “Men, women, young and old.” Around two years ago, [he noticed](#) non-Irish Americans posting videos of themselves [splitting](#) the ‘G.’ He had first seen the trend around 2017 and watched it spread from London to Ireland and, eventually, to the chug-happy United States. O’Sullivan was quick to act. In 2022, he replaced his un[branded](#) beer glasses with custom pints featuring Hartley’s logo so customers could split the ‘H’. The payoff was immediate. Guinness now outsells the rest of the menu by a 6-to-1 margin, he said. For anyone with an internet connection, [splitting](#) the ‘G’ has become inescapable across platforms, with searches for the trend peaking in the United States on Google Trends in mid-November. Singers Ed Sheeran and Niall Horan recently attempted the trend together. Actor Jason Momoa is a fan, too, and there’s even a split the ‘G’ app. Guinness has not publicly [endorsed](#) the trend, although He, the brand director, said [splitting](#) the ‘G’ has been a positive [driver](#) of sales in the United States. “I love seeing people get creative about making Guinness their own and creating their new rituals with the brand,” she said. “As long as it’s done responsibly.” While the Guinness sold in the United States is still brewed in and imported from Ireland, the quality of pints [poured](#) at [stateside](#) bars has improved with demand. “Guinness is our [signature dish](#),” said Fergus Carey, an owner of Fergie’s Pub in Philadelphia. He [pours](#) his pints into twenty-ounce [568.2ml] imperial pint glasses, as is customary in Ireland, and takes several minutes to do so. “We take it very seriously,” he said. Thirty years ago, when Carey first opened the pub, he [poured](#) Guinness into sixteen-ounce [454ml] American pint glasses, which any Irishman will tell you is a mistake. Most of his customers didn’t care. “A lot of Irish people, when they moved to the States, they would not drink Guinness because at most places, it was [crap](#),” he said. New York State of Pint, an Instagram account managed by three Irishmen, is dedicated to finding the best pints of Guinness in New York City. They consider a variety of factors, such as temperature, [glassware](#) and appearance. Even the time it takes for the nitrogen to [settle](#) in a [pour](#) can affect a Guinness’ rating. “You would be amazed by the differences between pints,” said one reviewer, who requested anonymity to ensure their review process is [not swayed](#) by special treatment. Despite Guinness’ reach, their favourite is still at an Irish pub: Hartley’s, which they [awarded](#) an 8.5. O’Sullivan, the New York pub owner, is looking for new ways to capitalize on his customers’ [urge](#) to split the ‘G’. He plans [to lower](#) the logo on his [branded](#) glasses at Grace’s in Manhattan by a few centimeters, to match the ones at Hartley’s. “It’s for consistency,” he said. “But of course, it’s also for business.” © 2024 The New York Times Company. **This article originally appeared in **The New York Times**. **

Glossary

- **his head back** = inclinare indietro
- **gulp** = ingoiare
- **purchasing** = acquistare
- **keg's tap** = rubinetto del barile
- **urge** = desideri
- **to lower** = scendere
- **sparkling wines** = vini frizzanti
- **foam** = schiuma
- **splitting** = dividere
- **appeals to** = attrarre
- **outsold** = vendere più di
- **awarded** = assegnare
- **branded** = con il marchio
- **winning over** = conquistare
- **diners** = ristorante economico, piccolo ristorante
- **meal in a glass** = pasto in un bicchiere
- **dispelling** = sfatare
- **glassware** = vetreria
- **not swayed** = influenzare
- **brewery** = birrificio
- **byproduct** = sottoprodotto, prodotto secondario
- **pour** = versare
- **shedding** = liberarsi
- **craft beer's** = birra artigianale
- **he noticed** = accorgersi
- **spot** = individuare
- **driver** = fattore determinante
- **settle** = depositarsi
- **endear** = affezionarsi
- **signature dish** = piatto forte
- **uptick** = aumento
- **to chug** = scolarci
- **stout** = birra scura
- **motley** = variegato
- **rocketing** = in forte crescita
- **top-performing markets** = mercati di maggiore successo
- **wearied** = stanchi
- **stateside** = negli Stati Uniti
- **stepped out** = uscire
- **chill** = freddo

- **beer-bent** = appassionati di birra
- **making up** = recuperare
- **bananas** = pazzesco
- **hardly trendy** = tutt'altro che di moda
- **endorsed** = appoggiare
- **crap** = porcheria, robbaccia